A Complete Small Group Study Resource

Jude 17–23

The Believer’s Response: Build, Pray, Keep, Rescue

Small Group Bible Study Series · Jude

Source: The Gospel Vault

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Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NASB · Jude 17–23

17 *But you, beloved, ought to remember the words that were spoken beforehand by the apostles of our Lord Jesus Christ,*

18 *that they were saying to you, "In the last time there will be mockers, following after their own ungodly lusts."*

19 *These are the ones who cause divisions, worldly-minded, devoid of the Spirit.*

20 *But you, beloved, building yourselves up on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Spirit,*

21 *keep yourselves in the love of God, waiting anxiously for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ to eternal life.*

22 *And have mercy on some, who are doubting;*

23 *save others, snatching them out of the fire; and on some have mercy with fear, hating even the garment polluted by the flesh.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

> *"But you, beloved, building yourselves up on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Spirit, keep yourselves in the love of God, waiting anxiously for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ to eternal life."*

After sixteen verses about them, Jude turns and looks his readers in the eye: “But you, beloved.” Not those people. You. And what follows is not more description of the threat, but a way of life: build, pray, keep, wait.

The building is on a foundation already laid. The praying is in the Holy Spirit, who intercedes through us. The keeping is within a love already given. The waiting is for a mercy that is coming. These are not the things people do to become secure. They are what the secure do.

And out of that grounded, Spirit-filled, hope-oriented life, the hands reach out — gently to those who doubt, urgently to those in the fire, and carefully to those deeply stained. The same grace that keeps you is what you hand on.

Reflect

1. Of the four — build, pray, keep, wait — which is most alive in you right now, and which needs attention?
2. Think of someone who is doubting, in danger, or deeply entangled. Which kind of mercy do they need?
3. How does waiting for Christ’s mercy change the way you carry present pressure?

You do not build in order to be kept. You build because you already are.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **Proposition.** Having shown what the intruders are, Jude tells the beloved what to do: remember what the apostles said, build on the faith, pray in the Spirit, keep themselves in God's love, wait for Christ's mercy, and reach out with mercy fitted to each person's danger.

Introduction — The Turn from Warning to Action

Everything in the letter so far has been descriptive. Jude has named the infiltrators (vv. 3–4), set out the precedents (vv. 5–11), and painted their portrait (vv. 12–16). It is thorough and alarming. But a good physician does not stop at the diagnosis. He prescribes.

The turn comes in three words that change the whole tone of the letter: "But you, beloved." After sixteen verses of "these are" and "they are," Jude looks at his readers. Not the intruders, not the wavering, not the compromised. You, beloved — the same word he used in verses 1 and 3. The community that is kept for Jesus Christ and prayed over for multiplied mercy now receives its instructions.

Verses 17–23 are among the most practically wise in the New Testament on how to live faithfully in the middle of a doctrinal conflict. Jude does not give a battle plan or a list of people to confront. He gives a way of life: a call to memory (vv. 17–19), four disciplines for the community's inner life (vv. 20–21), and three graduated ways of reaching those on the margins (vv. 22–23). The movement is from stability to reach: be grounded first, then extend the hand.

I. Remember: Stability through Apostolic Memory – vv. 17–19

A. "You ought to remember"

Jude's first instruction is to remember. His readers already know what he is about to say; he points them to what the apostles had told them beforehand. The problem under pressure is not ignorance but forgetfulness. What is known recedes as what is felt advances.

B. What the apostles said

The prediction is specific: "In the last time there will be mockers, following after their own ungodly lusts." Paul had warned the Ephesian elders in nearly the same terms (Acts 20:29–30), and Peter had written of false teachers rising among the people (2 Peter 2:1–3; 3:3). The pastoral effect of Jude's "remember" is easily missed: the presence of these men is not evidence that the church is failing. It is evidence that the apostles were right. A community that has been watching does not need to be surprised. What is happening is the fulfillment of what they were told to expect. That is stabilizing. The ground has not shifted; only the weather has changed.

C. The marks, once more

Verse 19 names them one last time: "These are the ones who cause divisions, worldly-minded, devoid of the Spirit." "Worldly-minded" is *psychikoi* — literally "soulish," governed by the natural, lower life without the Spirit's governance (compare 1 Corinthians 2:14). They

divide the very community they have entered. And they are “devoid of the Spirit.” That stands in deliberate contrast to what Jude commands next: “praying in the Holy Spirit.” The line between the two communities is the Spirit.

II. Four Disciplines for the Community – vv. 20–21

Verses 20–21 are Jude’s complete positive prescription. Four things are said of the beloved, and they are not four separate activities but one integrated posture of faithful life.

A. Building yourselves up on your most holy faith – v. 20a

Epoikodomountes pictures construction — one course of stone laid upon another, rising in height and strength. The foundation is already given: “your most holy faith,” the apostolic deposit of verse 3. The community does not need to discover or invent it. Its task is to build on it, through teaching, study, worship, and living by what has been given. The adjective is a superlative: the faith is set apart, sacred, not subject to compromise. Building on it means handling it with reverence — not reshaping it for cultural comfort.

Paul uses the same picture. “Let each man be careful how he builds” on the foundation which is Christ (1 Corinthians 3:10–15), and believers are “rooted and built up in Him and established in your faith” (Colossians 2:6–7; cf. Ephesians 2:20). The foundation is Christ and the apostles’ teaching, and what we build on it will be examined. Jude’s instruction is the same: keep adding to what was given, do not tear it down and start over.

B. Praying in the Holy Spirit – v. 20b

Praying in the Holy Spirit is not a special technique. It describes prayer that comes from the Spirit’s leading and is aligned with His purposes, not merely our preferences and worries. Paul develops the same idea in Romans 8:26–27: the Spirit helps us in our weakness and intercedes for us. The contrast with verse 19 is structural. The intruders are devoid of the Spirit. The faithful community is defined by His presence and activity. Because the Spirit does not divide but unites, a community that prays in Him has an answer to the division the intruders cause.

The practical shape of this is easy to miss. A church that prays together, with the Spirit’s direction, is a church that is not at the mercy of the latest wind of teaching. It puts its requests alongside the Father’s purposes and listens. Paul calls it praying “at all times in the Spirit,” and ties it to alertness “with all perseverance and petition for all the saints” (Ephesians 6:18). It is as much a defense against drift as any careful study.

C. Keeping yourselves in the love of God – v. 21a

The third discipline carries the most theological weight. The verb is *tēreō* again — the same root as “kept for Jesus Christ” in verse 1, and now it is an imperative: “keep yourselves in the love of God.” It is worth facing the tension directly, not smoothing it over. God keeps His people (v. 1; v. 24). Believers are told to keep themselves (v. 21). Which is it?

Both, on different levels. God’s keeping concerns the believer’s standing — his security in Christ and the preservation that ends in the presentation of verse 24. The believer’s keeping concerns the relational and experiential side: remaining consciously within the love God has already given. John 15:9–10 is the exact parallel: “Abide in My love.” The command to abide

is not a condition for the love to continue; the love is already there. It is an invitation to live fully within it. The Reformed reading takes verse 21 as one of the means by which God secures the perseverance of the elect.[1] The Free Grace reading takes it as a call to walk in what is already true, with the benefits of fellowship and reward at stake, not the standing itself.[2] Keeping yourself in God's love is the opposite of drifting — and drift is exactly what the intruders have done.

D. Waiting anxiously for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ – v. 21b

The fourth is eschatological. *Prosdechomenoi* is eager, expectant waiting, not passive resignation. The community is to live with its eyes on Christ's return and its hope directed toward "eternal life." This is not eternal life as something still to be acquired; the community already has it (John 5:24; 1 John 5:13). It is eternal life in its fullness — the complete, unobstructed experience of the life they already possess, brought to completion at His appearing.

An eschatological horizon does not lower the urgency of the present; it frames it. A community whose hope is fixed on Christ's mercy is not finally defined by its current conflicts. Its horizon is wider than the false teachers, wider than the present crisis.

Paul calls this expectation "the blessed hope and the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior, Christ Jesus" (Titus 2:13), and says it teaches us to deny ungodliness and live sensibly now (Titus 2:11–12). The Thessalonians turned to God "to wait for His Son from heaven" (1 Thessalonians 1:10). Waiting is not wasted time; it is how people live who know the end of the story.

III. Three Rescue Postures – vv. 22–23

The last movement is among the wisest pastoral instructions in the New Testament. Jude does not give one posture for all people in danger. He gives three, fitted to how far each person has moved toward the error and how near he is to harm. (The manuscripts differ here — some witnesses have two groups, others three — but the NASB follows the three-group reading, and the principle holds either way: different people need different responses.)

A. Mercy for those who are doubting – v. 22

"Have mercy on some, who are doubting." These are the wavering — not settled in the false teaching and not settled in the truth, caught in an inner dispute. They are asking hard questions, drawn by some of what the intruders offer. The response is mercy: patient, non-condemning engagement. The temptation is to write them off. Jude says no. The person in the middle is still reachable, and an open hand does more than a pointed finger.

Jesus Himself models this. A father says, "I do believe; help my unbelief" (Mark 9:24), and Jesus does not rebuke him; He heals the boy. Thomas will not believe without seeing, and eight days later Jesus appears and says, "Reach here with your finger, and see My hands" (John 20:24–29). The Lord met the doubter with patience and evidence, not scorn. That is the pattern for ministry to the wavering: patient, honest, with presence and truth.

B. Snatching others out of the fire – v. 23a

"Save others, snatching them out of the fire." These are further along — close enough to danger that patience gives way to urgency. The image comes from Zechariah 3:2, where Joshua the high priest is called "a brand plucked from the fire," and Amos 4:11. The word "save" (*sōzō*) has a broad range in the New Testament. It can mean physical rescue (Matthew 14:30), healing, and deliverance from various dangers, not only eternal salvation. James 5:19–20 uses similar language of turning a wandering brother back from error and saving his soul from death. Here the rescue most naturally refers to deliverance from a present spiritual danger.[3] Many Reformed interpreters read it as eternal salvation, and the passage can bear that reading; we take it as rescue of those who have drifted perilously near the edge.

Rescue like this is urgent, not careless. A rescuer enters a fire with speed and with awareness of the danger. You cannot help someone out of a burning building if you lose your bearings inside it.

James puts it plainly: "My brethren, if any among you strays from the truth and one turns him back, let him know that he who turns a sinner from the error of his way will save his soul from death and will cover a multitude of sins" (James 5:19–20). Paul adds the caution that fits the third group: "if anyone is caught in any trespass, you who are spiritual, restore such a one in a spirit of gentleness; each one looking to yourself, so that you too will not be tempted" (Galatians 6:1). Rescue is for the spiritual — and the spiritual stay watchful. It is the same fear Jude has in mind.

C. Mercy with fear for the deeply stained – v. 23b

"On some have mercy with fear, hating even the garment polluted by the flesh." The picture is of clothing contaminated by disease or uncleanness (Leviticus 13:47–52; Zechariah 3:3–4). To touch it was to risk becoming unclean. These are people so deeply entangled that even helping them carries risk for the helper. Mercy is still the word — Jude does not say abandon them. But it is mercy with fear: mercy that refuses to pretend contamination is not real, and protects the rescuer's own spiritual health. That is not unkindness. It is the wisdom of a rescuer who knows he cannot help anyone if he is himself destroyed in the attempt.

The sophistication of these three is that they require the community to *assess*. A single posture applied to everyone is not discernment but laziness. The wavering need patient mercy. The endangered need quick action. The deeply stained need careful mercy. All three are love; they are not the same love.

Conclusion

The four disciplines of verses 20–21 give a complete program for the inner life of a community under threat: build, pray, keep, wait. They are not strategies for winning arguments. They are the life of a community that will outlast every false teacher, because it is rooted in what the false teachers can neither offer nor take away — the holy faith, the Holy Spirit, the love of God, and the hope of Christ's mercy.

And the three rescue postures show that such a community does not become a fortress for its own. It becomes strong enough to reach out with graduated wisdom. Every rescue is an extension of the grace that keeps the rescuers.

The passage ends where it began: beloved. “But you, beloved.” The storm is real, and so is the danger to those on the margins. But beloved people, kept by a God who is able, do not meet the storm alone.

Lord, build us up, and send us out.

Sources and Notes

1. Reformed reading of v. 21 as a means of perseverance: Thomas R. Schreiner and Ardel B. Caneday, *The Race Set Before Us: A Biblical Theology of Perseverance and Assurance* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2001); see also Thomas R. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, New American Commentary (Nashville: Broadman & Holman, 2003), on Jude 20–23.

2. Free Grace on assurance and fellowship: Robert N. Wilkin, *Confident in Christ: Living by Faith Really Works* (Denton, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 1999); Zane C. Hodges, *Grace in Eclipse* (Denton, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 2007), on rewards and fellowship; Charles C. Bing, *Simply by Grace* (Grand Rapids: Kregel, 2009).

3. On the range of *sōzō* in the New Testament: Blue Letter Bible lexicon entry G4982; BDAG, 3rd ed.; compare Matthew 14:30; Mark 5:34; James 5:19–20. Textual variants in vv. 22–23: see the NET Bible translators’ notes on Jude 22–23 and Thomas L. Constable, *Expository Notes on Jude*, planobiblechapel.org/tcon/notes/.

4. Word studies: Blue Letter Bible lexicon entries G3403 (*mimnēskomai*), G1703 (*empaiktēs*), G592 (*apodiorizō*), G5591 (*psychikos*), G2026 (*epoikodomeō*), G4336 (*proseuchomai*), G5083 (*tēreō*), G4327 (*prosdechomai*), G1653 (*eleeō*), G1252 (*diakrinō*), G726 (*harpazō*), G4695 (*spiloō*).

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.17	**μνήσθητε** remember	G3403 mnēsthēte Aor. Pass. Impv. 2nd Pl.	STR: to remember, be mindful. Significance: a decisive call to recover what they already know. Stability in crisis comes from memory, not new information.
v.18	**ἐμπαῖκται** mockers	G1703 empaiktai N-Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: a derider. Significance: the apostles had predicted exactly this. Cf. 2 Pet. 3:3.
v.19	**ἀποδιορίζοντες** cause divisions	G592 apodiorizontes Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: to separate, to make distinctions. Significance: a present, ongoing activity — they divide the community they have entered.
v.19	**ψυχικοί** worldly-minded	G5591 psychikoi Adj.-Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: soulish, natural. Significance: governed by the natural life, devoid of the Spirit. Cf. 1 Cor. 2:14. Stands in contrast with "praying in the Holy Spirit."
v.20	**ἐποικοδομοῦντες** building up	G2026 epoikodomountes Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: to build upon. Significance: ongoing, active construction on a foundation already laid.
v.20	**προσευχόμενοι** praying	G4336 proseuchomenoi Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: to pray. Significance: prayer in the sphere of the Holy Spirit — the Spirit's direction, not merely our preferences (Rom. 8:26–27).
v.21	**τηρήσατε** keep	G5083 tērēsate Aor. Act. Impv. 2nd Pl.	STR: to guard, keep. Significance: the fourth use of this root in the letter. God keeps believers (v. 1); believers keep themselves in His love — different levels, both true.
v.21	**προσδεχόμενοι** waiting anxiously	G4327 prosdechomenoi Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: to receive, to look for. Significance: eager, active expectation — not passive resignation.
v.22	**ἐλεᾶτε** have mercy	G1653 eleate Pres. Act. Impv. 2nd Pl.	STR: to show mercy. Significance: patient, compassionate engagement with the wavering. Echoes Jude's prayer for mercy in v. 2.
v.22	**διακρινομένους** doubting	G1252 diakrinomenous Pres. Mid. Ptc. Acc. Pl. Masc.	STR: to differ, to doubt. Significance: ongoing inner dispute — undecided, not committed to error. Cf. Jas. 1:6.
v.23	**σῴζετε** save	G4982 sōzete Pres. Act. Impv. 2nd Pl.	STR: to save, rescue. Significance: broad range (Matt. 14:30; Jas. 5:19–20). Here, rescue from present spiritual danger.

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.23	**ἁρπάζοντες** snatching	G726 harpazontes Pres. Act. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: to seize, snatch. Significance: forceful, quick action, like pulling a brand from the fire (Zech. 3:2).
v.23	**ἐσπιλωμένον** polluted	G4695 espilōmenon Perf. Pass. Ptc. Acc. Sg. Masc.	STR: to stain, defile. Significance: a garment contaminated — risk by contact. Cf. Zech. 3:3–4; Lev. 13.

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Impv. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
What does Jude call his readers to do in vv. 17–19, and why?	Remember the apostles' prediction. The crisis confirms their word instead of refuting it; recovered memory steadies the community.
What four things are said of the believers in vv. 20–21?	Building themselves up on their most holy faith, praying in the Holy Spirit, keeping themselves in the love of God, and waiting anxiously for the mercy of Christ unto eternal life.
How can God keep believers (v. 1) and believers keep themselves (v. 21)?	On different levels: God keeps their standing; they keep themselves in the relational enjoyment of His love — like abiding in John 15:9–10.
What does "eternal life" mean in v. 21?	The fullness of the life believers already have, completed at Christ's appearing (John 5:24; 1 John 5:13).
How do the three groups in vv. 22–23 differ, and what response fits each?	The wavering need mercy; the endangered need urgent rescue; the deeply stained need mercy with fear.
What does "save" (*sōzō*) mean in v. 23?	It can mean rescue from a present danger, as in Matthew 14:30 or James 5:19–20. Many Reformed writers read it as eternal salvation; we take it as rescue from drift.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. How does remembering what the apostles said help in a time of confusion? Share an example from your own life.

> *Leader note: See Commentary I.B.*

2. Which of the four disciplines — building, praying, keeping, waiting — is strongest in your church? Which is weakest?

> *Leader note: See Commentary II.A–D.*

3. What is the difference between "keeping yourself in God's love" and "earning your place in it"?

> *Leader note: See Commentary II.C — John 15:9–10; the Reformed and Free Grace readings.*

4. **Why do the three groups in vv. 22–23 need different responses?**

> *Leader note: See Commentary III.*

5. **Think of someone you know who fits one of the three groups. What does Jude say they need from you?**

> *Leader note: See Commentary III.A–C.*

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
vv. 17–19	Remember	The crisis was predicted. Memory steadies.
v. 20	Build and pray	Build on the holy faith; pray in the Holy Spirit.
v. 21	Keep and wait	Keep yourselves in God's love; wait anxiously for Christ's mercy.
v. 22	Mercy for the doubting	Patient, non-condemning engagement.
v. 23a	Rescue the endangered	Urgent snatching from the fire.
v. 23b	Mercy with fear	Careful help for the deeply stained.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

Application 1 — Let the Crisis Confirm the Word

Jude 17–18

Drawn from Commentary I. Key term: mnēsthēte (remember).

The usual responses to crisis are panic or denial. Jude offers a third: remember. The apostles said this would happen. The mockers have arrived on schedule, and that is a reason for steadiness, not alarm.

Reflection: Is there a pressure you have been treating as unprecedented? What did Scripture say about it beforehand?

Practical Step: Read Acts 20:29–30 and 2 Timothy 3:1–5 alongside Jude 17–18. Write one sentence on how seeing it as expected changes your posture.

Application 2 — The Four-Word Program

Jude 20–21

Drawn from Commentary II. Key terms: epoikodomountes, tērēsate, prosdechomenoi.

Build. Pray. Keep. Wait. These are not conditions of security but expressions of it. The kept community builds, prays, abides, and waits. Treat them as a room to live in, not a ladder to climb.

Reflection: As a group: which of the four is most visible in your community? Which is most absent?

Practical Step: Pick one of the four to focus on for two weeks. Be specific about what it will look like day to day.

Application 3 — Match the Posture to the Person

Jude 22–23

Drawn from Commentary III. Key terms: diakrinomenous, harpazontes, espilōmenon.

Using one posture for everyone in danger is a common failure. The wavering need patient mercy, the endangered need urgent rescue, and the deeply stained need mercy with caution. Discernment begins with honest assessment.

Reflection: Think of one person who is spiritually vulnerable. Which of the three fits them now?

Practical Step: Pray this week for discernment about what that person needs from you, then take one concrete step.

Application 4 — Rescue Flows from Rootedness

Jude 20–23

Drawn from Commentary Conclusion.

The order matters: four disciplines, then three rescues. A community that is not built up on the faith will not know which fire is dangerous; one that is not praying in the Spirit will not

know which posture to take. Rootedness produces discernment, and discernment makes rescue possible.

Reflection: Are you reaching out from a reserve that is being replenished, or from depletion?

Practical Step: Before your next difficult conversation, take ten minutes in Scripture, prayer, or thankfulness for God's love.

End of Study · Jude 17–23